

BONUS #1 · A PRINTABLE IDEA DECK



30 Creative Engagement Ideas

Open-ended art, pretend play, and build-it challenges that hold attention without step-by-step instructions — perfect for when your child needs to lead the way.

How to Use This Bonus

1

These are idea sparks, not worksheets — there is no wrong way to try them.

2

Let your child pick the idea, not you. Choice keeps them engaged longer.

3

The 3 'try this' tips on each card are optional add-ons, not requirements.

4

It's okay to stop halfway — the goal is engagement, not a finished product.

5

Mix and match: combine an Art idea with a Storytelling idea for extra fun.

Scribble Story



Make one big messy scribble on paper. Then hunt for hidden pictures inside it and color them in.



Turn the scribble sideways or upside down for new ideas.



Find at least 3 different pictures in one scribble.



Give each hidden picture a silly name.

Color Mixing Lab



Using only red, blue, and yellow, see how many brand-new colors you can invent.



Name every new color you make (like 'Dinosaur Green').



Try mixing with just a little water to make it lighter.



Make a color chart of your favorite mixes.

Draw Your Superpower



If you could have any superpower in the world, draw yourself using it right now.



Add a cape, symbol, or costume.



Draw the villain you'd fight with your power.



Write one sentence about how you got your power.

Sound Doodle



Hum a tune or play a song. Let the sound guide your hand — draw whatever shapes the music feels like.

- ✦ Try a fast song, then a slow song — compare the drawings.
- ✦ Use only lines, no pictures, just following the sound.
- ✦ Add color where the music feels 'loud'.

Monster Mash-Up



Draw a monster that is half one animal and half something totally different.

- ✦ Try half-shark, half-cupcake.
- ✦ Give your monster a name and a favorite snack.
- ✦ Decide if it's friendly or just misunderstood.

Blind Contour Drawing



Pick an object nearby. Draw it without ever looking down at your paper — only look at the object.

- ✦ It will look silly and that's the whole point!
- ✦ Try it with your own hand as the object.
- ✦ Compare it to a normal drawing of the same thing.

Finish the Doodle



Draw one random squiggle or shape on paper. Then turn it into anything you can imagine.

- ✦ Ask someone else to draw the starting squiggle for you.
- ✦ Try turning the same squiggle into 3 different things.
- ✦ The weirder the result, the better.

Texture Rubbing Hunt



Find 5 different bumpy or textured surfaces around the house. Put paper over each one and rub a crayon on top.

- ✦ Try a wall, a coin, a leaf, a shoe sole, a placemat.
- ✦ Guess the texture before you find out what it was.
- ✦ Make a 'texture collage' page of all 5.

Design Your Dream Room



Draw or describe the coolest bedroom you could ever imagine having.

- ✦ Include a secret feature, like a hidden door or slide.
- ✦ Decide what's on the walls and the floor.
- ✦ Add one thing that only exists in your imagination.

Paint With Anything



Find something that isn't a paintbrush — a cotton swab, a fork, a leaf, a sponge — and paint with it instead.

- ✦ Try 3 different objects on the same page.
- ✦ Guess what texture each object will make before trying.
- ✦ Name your new 'invented' painting tool.

Sock Puppet Show



Turn a sock into a puppet with a face and put on a two-minute show for someone.

- ✦ Give your puppet a name and a favorite food.
- ✦ Make up a tiny problem for the puppet to solve.
- ✦ Try a different voice for the puppet.

Story Dice



Pick 3 random objects near you right now. Make up a story that includes all three of them.

- ✦ Reroll by picking 3 new objects for another story.
- ✦ Try telling it backwards, ending first.
- ✦ Add a funny villain to the story.

What Happens Next?



Start a story with one sentence. Take turns with someone adding just one more sentence each time.

- ✦ No planning allowed — just say what pops into your head!
- ✦ Try to make the story as silly as possible.
- ✦ See how long you can keep it going.

Become the Weather



Act out being a thunderstorm, then a gentle breeze, then a bright sunny day.

- ✦ Use your whole body and your voice for each one.
- ✦ Add sound effects for rain, wind, and sunshine.
- ✦ Ask someone to guess which weather you're acting out.

Restaurant Pretend



Set up a pretend restaurant. Take turns being the chef, the customer, and the waiter.

- ✦ Make up a silly menu with invented food names.
- ✦ Take a pretend order and 'cook' it up.
- ✦ Add a rating at the end: how was the food?

Animal Detective



Pretend to be a detective animal solving a silly mystery somewhere in the house.

- ✦ Decide what animal your detective is and how they walk and talk.
- ✦ Invent a 'case' like the Mystery of the Missing Sock.
- ✦ Find 3 clues to solve it.

Talking Toys



Pick two toys or objects. Give each one a different voice and let them have a conversation.

- ✦ Give them opposite personalities.
- ✦ Make them disagree about something silly.
- ✦ Let them become best friends by the end.

Superhero Origin Story



Invent a brand-new superhero name and tell the story of how they got their powers.

- ✦ Decide their one weakness.
- ✦ Give them a catchphrase they always say.
- ✦ Draw or act out their signature pose.

Time Traveler



Pretend you just traveled back 100 years. What do you see, eat, wear, and do all day?

- ✦ Compare it to your life today.
- ✦ Act out meeting someone from that time.
- ✦ Decide what you'd miss most from now.

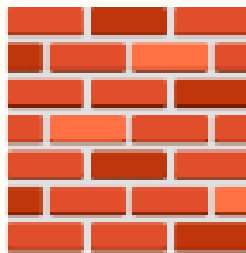
Shadow Puppet Tales



Use a flashlight and your hands to tell a story with shadow puppets on the wall.

- ✦ Practice a few hand shapes first (bird, dog, rabbit).
- ✦ Turn off other lights to make shadows extra clear.
- ✦ Add a simple beginning, middle, and end.

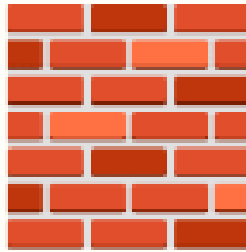
Tallest Tower



Build the tallest tower you can using blocks, cups, or books. Can it hold a small toy on top without falling?

- ✦ Try a wider base for more stability.
- ✦ Time yourself and try to beat your record.
- ✦ Test what happens with a gentle 'earthquake' shake.

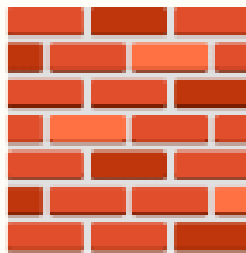
Pillow Fort HQ



Build a cozy fort using pillows and blankets, then give it a secret name and a special job it does.

- ✦ Add a flashlight for reading inside.
- ✦ Decide who is allowed in (the password!).
- ✦ Make a little sign for the entrance.

Recycled Robot



Use empty boxes, tubes, and containers to build a robot out of things you'd normally recycle.



Give your robot a name and one special power.

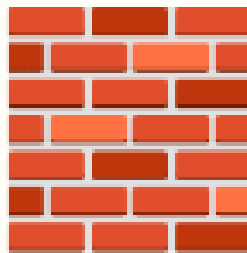


Decorate it with markers or stickers.



Decide what job your robot does all day.

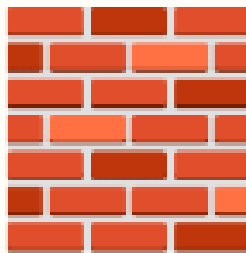
Bridge Builder



Using paper and tape, build a bridge strong enough to hold a small toy car.

- ✦ Try folding the paper to make it stronger.
- ✦ Test different bridge shapes.
- ✦ See how many toy cars it can hold at once.

Marble Run



Build a path for a marble or small ball to roll down using tubes, books, or ramps.



Try adding a loop or a jump.

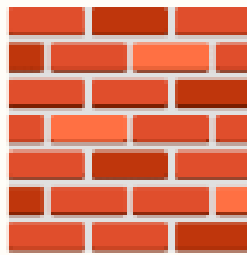


Time how fast the marble reaches the end.



Rebuild it a totally different way.

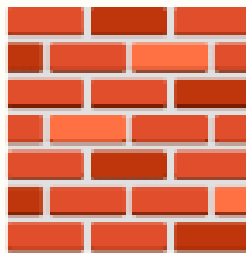
Balance Challenge



Using only 10 objects from around you, build a structure that stands on its own without falling.

- ✦ Try building with your eyes closed for one part.
- ✦ See how tall you can go with exactly 10 objects.
- ✦ Test it with a gentle poke — does it survive?

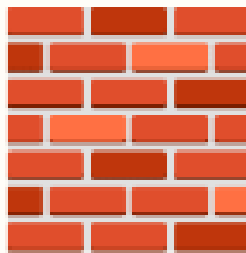
Secret Hideout Map



Design a map of an imaginary secret hideout, including traps, rooms, and hidden treasure.

- ✦ Add a legend explaining the symbols.
- ✦ Mark an 'X' where the treasure is buried.
- ✦ Invent a name for your hideout.

Sock Ball Catapult



Build a simple catapult using a spoon and a rubber band to launch a soft object like a balled-up sock.



Measure how far it launches.

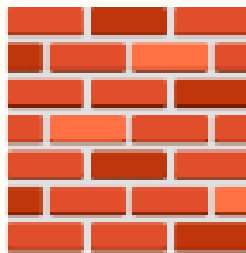


Try adjusting the angle to launch farther.



Set up a target to aim for.

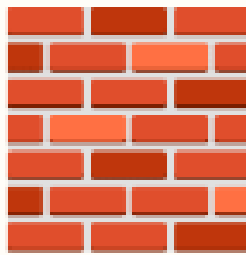
Invent a Machine



Build a pretend machine out of household objects and explain exactly what it does.

- ✦ Give it a funny, official-sounding name.
- ✦ Decide what buttons or levers it has.
- ✦ Draw a diagram of how it works.

Card Tower



Stack playing cards or index cards into a tower or pyramid. How high can you build before it falls?



Try a pyramid shape for extra stability.



See if a partner can add just one more card.



Rebuild it after it falls — don't stop at one try!

YOU DID IT!



Great Creating!

Every idea you tried builds imagination, flexible thinking, and focus —
one open-ended moment at a time.

END OF BONUS #1